NUTRITION

Heart-healthy eating with everyday foods

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Patient education. Follow your healthcare team’s advice.

What does heart-healthy eating mean?

Heart-healthy eating is about your usual food choices, not a single meal. Aim for a pattern that includes vegetables, fruits, whole grains, and healthy sources of protein, while limiting sodium, added sugars, and saturated fat. Your care team can help you adapt it to your health, budget, and food preferences. [1,3,4]

Use familiar ingredients

Meals do not need expensive imported ingredients. Consider vegetables you already buy, beans such as munggo, tofu, fish, and whole grains when available. These are examples of food groups included in heart-healthy guidance. Preparation matters too. Ask your nutrition counselor how to adjust portions and cooking methods for the dishes your household enjoys, without changing every meal at once. [1,2,5]

Pay attention to sodium

Salt is only one source of sodium. Packaged food, seasonings, sauces, and processed meat may also contribute. Compare labels using the same serving size. Look for lower-sodium options when possible. Herbs, spices, garlic, or citrus can add flavor without relying only on salt. Ask your doctor what sodium limit is right for you, particularly if you have heart failure or high blood pressure. [2]

Choose fats and drinks thoughtfully

Heart-healthy guidance favors unsaturated fats over sources high in saturated fat. Limit fatty and processed meats, and consider suitable plant oils in modest amounts. Coconut oil is high in saturated fat. Sugary drinks can add substantial sugar without making a meal more nourishing. If you have a fluid restriction, follow your prescribed allowance. Do not start drinking alcohol for supposed heart benefits. [1,2]

Make shopping more manageable

Before shopping, list the meals you expect to prepare and check what is already in the kitchen. Choose one change you can afford, such as adding vegetables to a usual dish or comparing two products for sodium. Keep the plan small enough to repeat. Ask the person who buys or cooks food to join the nutrition discussion if you want their help.

Bring real meals to the discussion

Write down a typical day of eating, including snacks, sauces, and drinks. The record helps your team understand your usual meals. Show it to your care team and ask which change would be most useful. Tell them about poor appetite, chewing problems, food allergies, or difficulty paying for meals. Advice works best when it accounts for your daily life.

Avoid a one-size-fits-all diet

People with kidney disease, diabetes, heart failure, or other conditions may need specific guidance. A popular diet or online meal plan may not fit those needs. Ask before using salt substitutes or supplements. Keep a written copy of any instructions you receive so family members can help without guessing. Clarify whether an instruction is temporary or part of your ongoing plan.

Build habits you can keep

Choose one food change you can afford and repeat. Review it with your team at the next visit. If it does not work, explain why so the plan can be adjusted.

References

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2. National Heart, Lung, and Blood Institute. (n.d.). Choose heart-healthy foods. https://www.nhlbi.nih.gov/health/heart-healthy-living/healthy-foods

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5. World Health Organization. (n.d.). Healthy diet. https://www.who.int/news-room/fact-sheets/detail/healthy-diet

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